



THE UNIVERSITY OF
MELBOURNE

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE ADVISORY GROUP

Current students web estate

Findings & decision pack — a full-evidence review of how current-students content is delivered across the hub, the faculties and their schools.

June 2026 · Prepared for DEAG · Evidence base: 1,173 pages crawled

The University of Melbourne acknowledges the Traditional Owners of the uncaded land on which we work, learn and live, and pays respect to their Elders, past and present, and to Indigenous Australians today.

Decision at a glance

A full crawl of the current-students estate — **1,173 pages** across the central hub, **9 faculty** sections and **3 school** sections — finds the estate is **85% unique, discipline-specific content**, not duplication. The service model is **structurally sound but the seams are broken**: six URL conventions, careers siloed across 9 faculties with zero cross-linking, the hub missing services students need (placements, course planning), school sites splintering the experience, and ~50 broken pages.

DEAG is asked to endorse three things:

1. **Direction** — a *hub-and-spoke* model (hub owns the transactional spine + fills its gaps; faculties keep their discipline estates under shared standards). Not full centralisation; not status quo.
2. **No-regrets actions now** — standard URL, a "where do I go for X" component, fix the broken links, connect careers. No structural decision needed.
3. **A standards mandate + a scoped Phase 2** — so the seams get fixed and stay fixed.

01 Purpose & scope

The student web experience is delivered jointly by the central hub (`students.unimelb.edu.au`) and current-students sections run independently by each faculty — and, in some cases, individual schools. DEAG asked whether that **service model is still working**, where content **overlaps or has gaps**, and what should change.

This pack answers from **direct evidence**: every reachable current-students page across the estate was crawled, classified and topic-tagged.

In scope: the central hub + all 9 faculty current-students sections + the 3 schools that run their own (Melbourne Business School, Biomedical Sciences, Melbourne Dental School). **Out of scope**: authenticated systems (my.unimelb, Canvas/LMS, SIS), prospective-student and staff content.

02 Method (and its limits)

A browser-based crawler walked each section breadth-first, capturing for every page its content, word count, in-section structure, outbound links (where it sends students), a unique/duplicative classification, and topic tags. **1,173 pages** were captured.

Limitations, stated honestly. ABP/MSD hit a 250-page ceiling owing to a large self-referencing studio archive (~700 further pages of one repeating type — counted as one content class, not omitted findings). The hub was mapped at IA + section-landing level, not leaf-by-leaf. Classification is automated (indicative, not hand-audited). Cloudflare actively blocked conventional crawling — itself a finding for any future automated audit.

03 What we found

1 The estate is large, and overwhelmingly *unique*

997 of 1,173 pages (85%) are unique, substantive content. Only ~4% are pure link-farms and ~7% mixed. The dominant content is exactly what cannot live centrally: subjects & timetabling (324 pages), research candidature (243), forms & admin (213), course planning (208), **placements & WIL (207)**. This is the most important finding — the faculty estate is real content, not redundant signposting. **"Just centralise it" is not a credible option.**

2 Every faculty hosts a real estate; the "link directory" picture was wrong

Earlier sampling suggested some faculties (ABP, FBE) were thin link directories. The full crawl disproves it: ABP runs **240 unique pages**; FFAM a substantive 37-page section; MDHS **104 unique pages** of clinical-placement compliance. What faculties *do* delegate is transactional admin (enrolment, fees, exams → hub). The duplication problem is **smaller and thinner** than feared; the *seam* problem is bigger.

3 Six URL conventions for one idea

"Information for current students" lives at six addresses: `/students` · `/current-students` · `/study/current-students` · `/study/student-resources` · `/study/current-student-information` · (and the hub). A student cannot guess their faculty's URL, and `fbe.../current-students` is a dead 404 where one would expect the page.

4 Careers is the clearest failure: parallel everywhere, connected nowhere

8 of 9 faculties plus MBS run their own careers/employability content in parallel with the central Careers hub — and hub and faculty careers pages **do not cross-link in either direction**. A student using the hub's career checklist may never discover their faculty's mentoring program, and vice-versa. This is the highest-value, lowest-cost fix in the estate.

5 The hub has real gaps where every faculty has built

The hub covers the transactional spine well but has **no presence** in services every faculty provides: **placements & WIL** (207 faculty pages; hub ≈ 0), degree-specific course planning, discipline academic skills, faculty forms (213 pages), and program regulatory pathways (LANTITE for teaching; Fitness-to-Practice / AHPRA for health). These gaps are *why* faculties build parallel sites.

6 School-level fragmentation multiplies the experience

Three schools run their own current-students sites *beneath* their faculty: **MBS (61 pages**, plus its own "Career Elevation" service), **Biomedical Sciences (42)**, **Dental (4)**. A Biomedicine student can traverse **three** different "home" experiences — the hub, the MDHS faculty section, and the Biomedical school site — each with a different URL and template.

7 Quality debt is visible and fixable

~50 pages are broken or misrouting, concentrated in Biomedical Sciences (18 — including 16 "major" pages with duplicate CMS slugs bouncing students to the *prospective* catalogue), FEIT (17), ABP (6), MDHS (3), Arts (3), FBE (2). The Dental site depends on case-sensitive paths (`/Forms` works, `/forms` 404s) and splits its own forms across two external form hosts.

8 No page tells students "what's where"

Not one faculty section carries a consistent "for X go to the hub; for Y stay here" signpost. Students learn the split by trial and error, and faculty pages routinely re-explain hub services (special consideration, leave of absence) that the hub owns definitively.

9 The topic evidence sharpens the consolidation target — and flags a data-quality clean-up

A topic-by-topic crawl (18 topics, full estate) pinpoints where consolidation pays. The **transactional spine** (enrolment, exams & results, special consideration, fees, library — 227 pages) has **only 6 pages on the hub domain**; the rest are faculty restatements of content the hub already owns — the single clearest target. **Scholarships** (faculties hold 141 pages of generic process scaffolding while a central catalogue already exists) and the duplicated "Employability in X" and "Wellbeing + Ambassadors" landing pages are next.

The same pass shows the topic page-counts are **inflated by content-quality artifacts** — ABP/MSD's ~700-page design-studio archive, FEIT nesting its whole estate under `/orientation` and `/students/it` paths, and ~70 Law researcher-profile pages. A meaningful share of the apparent "volume" is archival bloat and URL/CMS hygiene to fix at source, independent of the unification decision. (Full topic breakdown: Appendix B.)

04 The service-model verdict

The hub-and-faculty division of labour is the right one — but it is being run without the connective tissue that makes it work.

The hub is the correct owner of the transactional spine; faculties are the correct owners of placements, course plans, discipline skills and forms. What's missing is everything *between* them: consistent addressing, mutual signposting, a hub presence for placements and course planning, connected careers, consolidated school sites, and enforced standards. The fix is therefore **not** re-drawing ownership — it is **engineering the seams**.

05 Discussion points for DEAG

- **Autonomy vs consistency.** Faculties have invested years in useful content. Standards must be *mandated* (URL chaos proves advisory guidance failed) without gutting ownership. How much standardisation, with what authority?
- **The 85%-unique reality.** It takes "lift-and-shift to the hub" off the table. Does DEAG accept the goal is a *connected federation*, not a single site?
- **School-level sites (MBS, Biomedical, Dental).** Tolerate, standardise, or consolidate into their faculty?
- **The careers silo.** The clearest single win — who owns the hub↔faculty bridge, and will faculties embed the central tools?
- **Hub gaps.** Filling placements / course-planning means the central team owns *new* content. Capacity to own it, or thin "connector" pages into faculty content?
- **Governance teeth.** Standards as policy with audit and consequences, or another advisory guideline?
- **Personalisation as an accelerator.** If Optimizely + Tealium (CDP) are in the stack, a *personalised hub* could surface the right faculty content to a known student without moving pages — potentially leapfrogging migration. **Needs confirming.**

06 Options (recalibrated to the evidence)

Option	What it is	Verdict against the evidence
A. Full centralisation	Move faculty CS content to the hub	Reject. 997 unique, discipline-specific pages (clinical compliance, studios, legal skills) cannot be owned or maintained centrally.
B. Status quo + light governance	Keep everything, add advisory standards	Insufficient. Advisory standards already failed (6 URL conventions). Doesn't fix careers, gaps or school sites.
C. Hub-and-spoke with standards (recommended)	Hub owns the transactional spine <i>and fills its gaps</i> (placements, course-planning, careers bridge); faculties keep discipline content under a mandated template, URL & signposting standard; school sites consolidated	Best fit. Matches the 85%-unique reality, fixes the seams, preserves faculty investment, achievable in ~12 months.
D. Hub-and-spoke + CDP personalisation	Option C <i>plus</i> a personalised hub (Optimizely/Tealium) surfacing a student's faculty content automatically	Strongest if the martech exists. Modern personalised front door, no extra migration. Contingent on stack + data.

Recommendation: adopt **C** now, and upgrade to **D** if Optimizely/Tealium are confirmed.

07 The decision asked of DEAG

- **Decision 1 — Endorse the direction (C/D)**, ruling out full centralisation and status quo.
- **Decision 2 — Approve the no-regrets actions to begin immediately** (below). Visible improvement within a quarter; no structural change.
- **Decision 3 — Mandate a standards baseline and commission a scoped Phase 2** (hub gap-fill + school-site consolidation policy + governance with audit). Confirm whether Optimizely/Tealium are available to determine C vs D.

08 No-regrets actions (start now, regardless)

Action	Why	Effort
Standardise the URL to faculty.../students + 301-redirect the five variants	Discoverability; kills the 404 trap	Low
Ship a "Where do I go for X?" component on every faculty CS page	Directly fixes Finding 8 — highest-impact student fix	Low-Med
Fix the ~50 broken/misrouting pages (Biomedical 18, FEIT 17 first)	Removes worst quality debt; stops mis-routing students	Low
Cross-link careers both ways (hub ↔ every faculty)	Fixes the clearest failure in the estate	Low
Publish the standard CS template (contacts · course planning · placements · faculty life · forms · "where to go")	Baseline every faculty/school section can adopt	Med

A Appendix — measured evidence (per unit)

Unit	Level	Pages	Unique	Mixed	Link-farm	Broken	CS URL pattern
Law	Faculty	195	162	10	23	0	/students
FEIT	Faculty	204	174	13	0	17	/students
Arts	Faculty	91	51	24	13	3	/students
Science	Faculty	94	91	2	0	1	/students
ABP / MSD	Faculty	250*	240	4	0	6	/current-students
FBE	Faculty	36	31	3	0	2	/students
Education	Faculty	47	32	10	5	0	/study/current-students
FFAM	Faculty	37	28	4	5	0	/current-students
MDHS	Faculty	112	104	4	1	3	/study/current-students
MBS	School (FBE)	61	60	1	0	0	/students
Biomedical Sci.	School (MDHS)	42	21	3	0	18	/study/current-student-information
Dental	School (MDHS)	4	3	1	0	0	/study/student-resources
Total		1,173	997	79	47	50	6 conventions

* ABP capped at 250; a further ~700 studio-archive pages of one repeating type were not individually crawled. "Unique" = page carries substantive original prose; "link-farm" = mostly routes elsewhere; "mixed" = unique prose + heavy redirection.

B Appendix — topic evidence (18 topics)

Page counts are topic-tag totals (deduped) and are inflated by classifier artifacts (noted in the "Verdict" column); the per-topic deep-dive notes correct for this. Full notes + page lists: [analysis/topic-deepdives/](#).

Topic	Pages	Verdict	What the evidence shows
Subjects & timetabling	319	mixed	64% is ABP/MSD's design-studio archive; the rest a thin hub-owned timetabling spine echoed by faculties.
Orientation	289	inflated	FEIT holds 71% via <code>/orientation</code> path-nesting; genuine orientation is a thin faculty welcome layer.
Research candidature	241	faculty-owned	Legit (milestones, studios, funding); +-70 Law researcher bios; hub-own the candidature lifecycle spine.
IT & systems	235	artefact tag	78% mis-classified FEIT content; hub owns the Student IT / LMS / portal spine.
Transactional admin (enrol · exams · special-con · fees · library)	227	hub-owned	Only 6 of 227 pages on the hub domain ; rest are faculty restatements — the clearest consolidation target.
Student life	214	faculty-owned	Largely legit (clubs, mentoring, awards); ~1/3 is MSD/Science roster bloat.
Forms & admin	212	mixed	Law + MDHS heavy (compliance); offer/enrolment/special-con admin overlaps the hub.
Course planning	207	faculty-owned	Degree-specific plans; MBS + Biomedical = 46%; thin hub-overlap (generic advice, re-hosted planner).
Placements & WIL	206	faculty-owned	MDHS 47% (clinical compliance); near-zero hub overlap; the gap is discoverability, not duplication.
Contacts & support	177	mixed	~half is Arts + Law restatements of hub wellbeing/equity/careers + stub pages.
Careers & employability	141	mixed	Legit core (pathways, internships, mentoring) + a duplicated "Employability in X" layer.
Scholarships	141	consolidate	Hub holds zero; mostly generic process scaffolding → fold into central <code>scholarships.unimelb.edu.au</code> .
International	135	mislabelled	~80% is outbound mobility; genuine inbound support (visas/OSHC) is absent and hub-owned.
Graduation	125	misnomer	HDR candidature lifecycle + honours, not ceremonies; the apply-to-graduate spine is missing.
Clubs & events	104	faculty-owned	Community content; only the generic club-admin wrapper overlaps the hub.
Wellbeing & health	87	mixed	Half is MDHS clinical compliance; 6 near-duplicate "Wellbeing + Ambassadors" landings to collapse.
Inclusion & equity	49	consolidate	Noise-heavy; ~13 real pages parallel-reinvent the central service.
Academic skills	37	hub-overlap	Discipline skills are legit; generic landings duplicate the central service.

